

That epiphany finally led me to take another look at coupon fraud and how it applied to my own couponing practices. Evidently, I had inadvertently used at least one, and perhaps more, counterfeit coupons in my time.

Monitoring for fake coupons is something that Bud Miller, Executive Director of the Coupon Information Corporation (CIC) can spend a good portion of his day doing. In the six months after December 2009, his organization discovered 250 fake coupons, more than the previous decade combined. What does his agency do once they identify the counterfeit coupons? Miller emails food makers and retailers and posts alerts on popular couponing websites, as well as the CIC website, www.couponinformationcenter.com. In the month of May 2011 alone, there were twenty-five new counterfeit coupons posted on the CIC website.

Today, if you do a Google search for “coupon fraud” on the Internet, Bud Miller is one of the two names that inevitably appears; Jill Cataldo is the other. You can read dozens of statements attributed to Mr. Miller in the newspaper archives where he repeatedly contends that the only place a consumer should obtain coupons is from the newspapers they themselves buy off the stands. In other words, there should be no trading or purchasing of extra coupons.

Back in my couponing and refunding days, when I traded coupons and forms with women all over the country, I couldn't fathom Mr. Miller's hardline stance on coupon trading. Where was the harm? Later, when I got online and began ordering some extra coupons through the mail, I heard that Bud Miller wanted to see eBay and coupon handling websites suspend